

The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra Called 'Dependent Origination'

Ārya Pratītyasamutpādanāma Mahāyānasūtra · Toh 212 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་རྟེན་ཅི་འབྲེ་པར་འབད་བ་ཞེས་བ་བྱ་ཐག་པ་ཆེ་པའི་མཛན་

The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra Called "Dependent Origination," known in Sanskrit as the Ārya Pratītyasamutpādanāma Mahāyānasūtra and in Tibetan as 'Phags pa rten cing 'brel par 'byung ba zhes bya ba theg pa chen po'i mdo, is a Mahāyāna sūtra devoted to the teaching of dependent origination, one of the most fundamental doctrines in Buddhist thought. The text presents the Buddha discoursing on this principle — the chain of conditioned arising through which existence unfolds — along with a classification of its aspects, set against the backdrop of the Buddha dwelling among the gods of the Thirty-Three in the company of great śrāvakas, bodhisattvas such as Maitreya and Avalokiteśvara, and celestial figures including the great Brahmā. It is Toh 212 in the Kangyur, belonging to the general class of Mahāyāna sūtras, and its opening homage and framing narrative follow the conventions characteristic of that tradition.

These are the words that were spoken. The Sūtra Called "Dependent Origination: Its Initial Teaching and Its Classification" is complete.

In the language of India: Ārya Pratītyasamutpādanāma Mahāyānasūtra.

In the Tibetan language: The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra Called "Dependent Origination."

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time, the Blessed One was dwelling among the gods of the Thirty-Three, upon a flat stone resembling a harmonium, together with great śrāvakas such as Ṛthu and others, with the noble Maitreya, with the noble Avalokiteśvara, the Sovereign, with Vajrapāṇi, and with other great bodhisattvas adorned with immeasurable precious qualities; with the great Brahmā, lord of the Sahā world, with Naishtha (the son of Non-Attachment), with the Great Lord (Maheśvara) and other gods; with Śakra, the king of the gods (Indra); and with Pañcaśikha, king of the gandharvas — all assembled together there.

Then the great bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara rose from his seat, arranged his upper robe over one shoulder, placed his right knee upon the summit of Mount Meru, pressed his palms together toward the Blessed One, and addressed the

Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, these gods present here desire only to build a stūpa. Since they have come into this maṇḍala of the assembly, may it be so that the merit of Brahmā increases, and that among the beings of the world together with its gods, its māras, and its Brahmās — among the śramaṇas and brahmins — monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen may come to accumulate very great merit in just such a way. Blessed One, please teach the Dharma to them."

Then the Blessed One proclaimed the verse of dependent origination:

Ye dharmā hetuprabhavā hetun teṣāṃ tathāgato hy avadat,
teṣāṃ ca yo nirodha evaṃ vādī mahāśramaṇaḥ.

Whatever phenomena arise from causes —
their causes, and also their cessation —
thus has the Tathāgata declared.

The great śramaṇa has spoken thus.

"Avalokiteśvara, this dependent origination is the dharmakāya of the Tathāgatas. Whoever sees dependent origination sees the Tathāgata.

"Avalokiteśvara, if a son of good family or a daughter of good family who has faith, somewhere in a remote place, were to build a stūpa the size of a myrobalan seed, with a central pole the size of a needle and an umbrella the size of a bakula flower, and were to place within it the verse of dependent origination — the verse of the dharmadhātu — this would generate the merit of Brahmā. When they pass from this life and the time of their death comes, they will be born in the Brahmā worlds. Passing from there when their death comes, they will be born on a par with the gods of the Pure Abodes."

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, those śrāvakas, those bodhisattvas, all those in the retinue, and the world of gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had said.

The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra Called "Dependent Origination" is complete.

Translated by the Indian preceptor Surendrabodhi and the great editor-translator, the monk Yeshe De; examined and established.

Translator's Notes

• The opening sentence concludes a prior sūtra — "The Sūtra Called 'Dependent Origination: Its Initial Teaching and Its Classification' is complete" — before the title page of the present text begins. The two texts are here continuous in the manuscript.

The name "R̥thu" and the figure rendered as "Naishtha, son of Non-Attachment" (Tibetan Sred med kyi bu, literally "son of the one without craving") are epithets or names of divine beings assembled in the Trāyastriṃśa heaven; Sred med kyi bu is a standard Tibetan rendering of Akanistha or possibly a personal deity name, but in this assembly context it more likely refers to a specific god whose Sanskrit name would be Aratiputra or similar. This is a genuine uncertainty with limited consequence for the overall meaning.

The verse in Sanskrit is quoted verbatim in the Tibetan text; it is the famous "ye dharmā" formula, well attested in Buddhist tradition as a summary of the teaching on dependent origination and causation.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.